emergence of Sachin Pilot (16.4 per cent), hints at the generational change many within the party seek, though his numbers remain modest enough to pose no immediate challenge to the Family. The relatively low support for other potential leaders, including party president Mallikarjun Kharge (12.4 per cent), reinforces the sense that the Congress, for better or worse, remains inextricably linked to the Gandhi family in the public imagination.

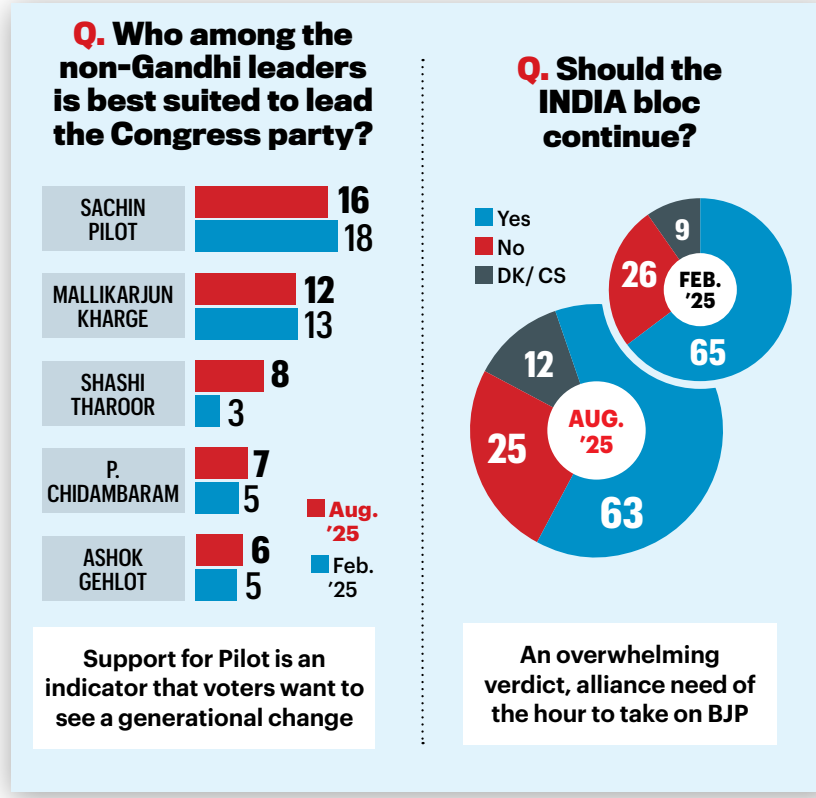
Testing Times Ahead

Even the party's relationship with allies remains complicated. The improved performance suggests that the Congress is regaining some legitimacy as the Opposition's anchor. Two-thirds of respondents view Congress as the 'real' opposition party, a psychological threshold that matters enormously in a political culture where perception often becomes reality. This acknowledgment, up slightly from earlier this year, suggests that despite the presence of strong regional parties and the formal structure of the INDIA bloc, the public still looks to the Congress as the primary vehicle for opposition to the BJP. For the INDIA bloc, this poses a balancing act: the Congress is indispensable, but its improving position risks alienating allies who fear being swallowed up in its shadow.

The question of the INDIA bloc's future adds another layer of complexity to the calculations. With 63.3 per cent supporting its continuation, a figure that has remained remarkably stable, there's clear public appetite for a united Opposition front. Yet the alliance faces its own internal contradictions, evident in the relatively low support for Mamata (7.7 per cent), Akhilesh (6.7 per cent), and Kejriwal (6.4 per cent) as potential alliance leaders. These numbers suggest that while voters want Opposition unity, they struggle to see any of the regional leaders as genuine national alternatives, potentially creating tensions within an alliance where many of them harbour prime ministerial ambitions.

Bihar, with its complex caste equations and history of coalition politics, has often served as a bellwether for national political trends. For Rahul and the Congress, it represents an opportunity to validate their emerging narrative around electoral integrity and what they call the systematic manipulation of the democratic process. The Congress's organisational weakness at the grassroots level, though, remains a worry here. That said, a strong performance by the INDIA bloc, with Congress playing a pivotal role, could provide the momentum needed to challenge the BJP's narrative dominance ahead of other state elections. Conversely, a poor showing could reignite questions about Rahul's leadership and the viability of the Opposition strategy. Bihar's significance is amplified by its symbolic importance—as one of India's poorest states with a large population of marginalised communities, it represents exactly the constituency that Congress claims to champion against what it characterises as the BJP's pro-corporate agenda.

What emerges from these numbers is a picture of an Opposition in transition, no longer in free fall but not yet ascendant. Modest gains in public perception, a measure of stability on leadership questions, and sustained backing for unity point to a political force that has arrested its decline and tentatively begun the work of rebuilding. But the distance to be covered to mount a credible challenge to the BJP's dominance remains enormous. The real test for the Opposition lies not only in countering the ruling party but in articulating a persuasive, cohesive vision capable of rallying India's diverse electorate. ■



All figures in % and rounded off; DK/ CS: Don't know, can't say

40 PER CENT

respondents in the South want Rahul Gandhi to lead the Opposition alliance, highest among all regions